

Council Meeting
June 12, 2024
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The Claremont City Council held a meeting on Wednesday, June 12, 2024, in the Council Chambers of City Hall.

The meeting was called to order by Mayor Girard at 6:30 p.m.

Members of the Council present:

Ward I Councilor Andrew O’Hearne
Ward II Councilor Brian Zutter
Ward III Councilor Jonathan Hayden - Absent
Assistant Mayor Debora Matteau
At-Large Councilor Wayne Hemingway
At-Large Councilor William Limoges
At-Large Councilor Nicholas Koloski
Mayor Dale Girard

Also present:

Yoshi Manale, City Manager

AGENDA CHANGES

Mayor Girard suggested a few budget items needed to be added to the agenda such as airport, revenue, and the Fire Department.

By Consensus City Council agreed to add these items to the end of old business.

REPORT OF THE SECRETARY

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Matteau and seconded by Councilor Limoges to accept the minutes of the May 15, 2024, City Council meeting.

Voice vote:

Koloski – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter– yes

Hemingway – yes

O’Hearne – abstain

Girard – yes

Motion carried 6-1(abstained)

A motion was made by Councilor Koloski and seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau to accept the minutes of the May 22, 2024, City Council meeting.

Voice vote:

Koloski – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter– yes

Hemingway – yes

O’Hearne – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 7-0

A motion was made by Councilor Limoges and seconded by Councilor Zutter to accept the minutes of the May 29, 2024, City Council meeting.

Voice vote:

Koloski – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter– yes

Hemingway – yes

O’Hearne – abstain

Girard – yes

Motion carried 6-1(abstained)

MAYOR’S NOTES

Mayor Girard read the Claremont Pride Proclamation with members of TLC.

Mayor Girard then read a Proclamation for the late Stan Andrews, his family was in attendance and Chief Wilmot accompanied them.

Mayor Girard gave a reminder that there is an open at large Council Seat and the deadline to apply is June 19th at 4 p.m.

Claremont Senior Center will be hosting an indoor yard sale this Friday and Saturday from 9am-3pm.

Saturday June 15th Real Steel Boxing Club has an event at the community center starting at 5pm.

Starting June 17th, the Claremont soup kitchen is providing free kid lunches from 12pm-1pm at the Claremont Soup Kitchen, 135 Maple Avenue, Veterans Park, Monadnock Park, and Barnes Park.

CITY MANAGER’S REPORT

Manager Manale announced the County has asked him to inform the public that there will be discussions of a County-wide community power agreement with the community power coalition of New Hampshire.

The CSBCC golf scramble event committee raised \$7,000 for scholarship funds.

Manager Manale introduced our new Treasurer, Cathy Parks.

APPOINTMENT TO BOARDS AND COMMITTEES

Parks and Recreation Commission

Councilor Koloski suggested to put these appointments off for a lack of attendance reports.

By Consensus the City Council agrees with moving parks and Recreation Committee appointments be moved to another meeting.

CCTV

A motion was made by Councilor Limoges and seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau for Dana McGrath to be appointed to Seat 2 on the CCTV Board of Directors.

Voice vote :

Koloski – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter– yes

Hemingway – yes

O’Hearne – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 7-0

Council Seats to Boards

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Matteau and seconded by Councilor Zutter for Councilor Hayden to be appointed to the Council Seat on the Conservation Commission.

Voice vote:

Koloski – opposed

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter– yes

Hemingway – yes

O’Hearne – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 6-1

CITIZEN’S FORUM

Mayor Girard gave reminder that Citizen’s forum is designed to allow you the opportunity to make the Council aware of your concerns. Please state your name and ward number, we ask you to address your concerns directly to the Council. The Council Manager will not be responding to you during this time. You are limited to five minutes on any non-agenda items. In the back of the room please write down your contact information if you’d like to be contacted as well as your concern on the Clipboard for follow up.

Heidi Hood, Ward 2, shared concern for the quality of sidewalks around town and worries about her chair being damaged, and has heard complaints from others. Ms. Hood noted it would be nice for attempts to be made to fix the sidewalks and is hoping it does by speaking tonight and then thanked everyone for listening.

Mike Tetu, Ward I, wants a copy of City Clerk email, and instead received an email from the Secretary of State. Mr. Tetu requested to move charter amendment from 2025 to 2024 and to be added onto the second meeting agenda in June.

Roberta Hood, aka robin Hood, Ward 1, Mrs. Hood noted she was proud of her youngest coming to speak, and stated loving the ramp but the door was locked. The walkway to the ramp is full of pitfalls, and stated Claremont is not paying the handicap population respect they deserve, commended the proclamation to the Pride Group and stated they can get in here, but handicap have trouble.

Gary Merchant, State Representative, Ward II, had a public service announcement about the State Property Tax Relief Program for low and moderate-income households.

Norm Blouin, Ward III, shared concern for the Council not having many questions about the budget, and stated Claremont is more stagnant, nothing is here and 90% of shopping is done online, there are no jobs, and stated we need employment.

No one else spoke, Mayor Girard closed the public hearing.

OLD BUSINESS

Ordinance 624 Taxi's Second Reading – Public Hearing

Manager Manale explained this ordinance will amend our current code and adds three offenses.

A motion was made by Councilor Limoges and seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau to accept Resolution 624.

Councilor Limoges read the explanation of proposed action into record.

Mayor Girard opened a public hearing, no one spoke. Mayor Girard closed the public hearing.

Voice vote:

Koloski – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter– yes

Hemingway – yes

O'Hearne – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 7-0

Water Budget

Director Gleeson noted he had reviewed the previous meeting to outline questions from the Council.

Director Gleeson then presented a PowerPoint for clarification from the previous meeting on residential Meter Lines, Contract labor and services, and Regular pay.

Mayor Girard asked for four quarters of what we have actually taken in revenues, because we must have four consecutive quarters that we can use for a total.

Manager Manale noted its 1.3 million, Mayor Girard asked if this included the metered flat rate,

commercial and industrial.

Director Bates stated that's residential meter, and 1.3 would be commercial, under the commercial rate.

Director Gleeson noted the flat rate, commercial, industrial are all separate lines.

Director Gleeson noted this is a one-time addition \$25,000.00 which is the estimated cost to replace that main gate valve

Mayor Girard asked if Director Gleeson will be replacing two vehicles

Councilor Koloski wanted to see a master lease schedule.

Manager Manale noted mentioning at the last meeting finance director Bates and himself will be putting together this list, and is looking for software.

Manager Manale stated this would be a significant amount of work by next week, and with respect that was not the request, and asked if we can move those numbers into capital project, And gave a reminder we have to even out the enterprise.

Councilor Koloski would like to put this off for water and sewer and bring back highway.

By Consensus City Council agrees to bring back Water, Sewer and Highway to the next budget meeting.

Budget

Revenue

Director Bates noted they are trying to achieve airport into an enterprise fund, gave explanations on repeated revenues that were deleted, and adjusted so the revenue and expenses match. The total revenue for the airport at this point is \$126,379.00.

Mayor Girard asked if everyone was good with a tentative approval or with that explanation, Council agreed the explanation was fine.

Mayor Girard noted needing to discuss two other line items in general revenues that were added in, that are now being moved out because it got moved to the airport section.

Director Bates noted state aeronautics revenue 001 which was \$3,000.00 got removed. That was repeated in the airport anyway, so that was a repeat revenue. The \$16,200.00 for the airport leases is now under 472. So that was removed from 001.

The total for general revenues is \$5,327,069.00.

Mayor Girard mentioned the expense line item for the airport, added back in the land M&R and machines and equipment.

Fire Department

Chief Chamberlain brought up the Washington St Signal Project, and noted all intersections are running on the Grid Smart program. Chief Chamberlain noted needing to update infrastructure with these signals, what's powering them in the background is old and outdated we would be chasing problems down the road. Four cabinets were identified that are in dire need of replacement, the cabinet serves as the overall brain of the traffic light. Chief worked with the Planning Director to put in a change order request to include those four cabinet replacements. In order to do so, the Fire Budget is coming back to see if there could be funds added into the traffic light line item. The total number which would be the 20% match is \$32,526.70 with the total cost being \$162,633.48.

Councilor Koloski stated being in favor of this.

Councilor Limoges and Assistant Mayor Matteau agree

Mayor Girard asked if adding \$32,000.00 made the total \$2,893,898.00.

Mayor Giard asked Council if they were okay with this number, Council agrees.

NEW BUSINESS

Resolution 2024-41 USDA Rural Business Development Grant – Public Hearing (City
Manager/Director of Planning and Development

Manager Manale explained the City had applied, and received funding for economic growth in downtown area with a 10% match of city worker's time.

Councilor Limoges asked how would the survey be conducted, Manager Manale stated a community forum.

RESOLUTION 2024-41

USDA Rural Business Development Grant

BE IT RESOLVED by the Claremont City Council, after a public hearing duly noticed, that:

WHEREAS the City was awarded \$50,000 from the USDA Rural Business Development program to be used to support business recruitment & retention efforts and small business startup programs in the downtown;

NOW THEREFORE BE IT RESOLVED THAT the City Council will accept and expend up to \$50,000 in grant funding for the purposes of the grant;

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED THAT the City Manager or his designees are hereby authorized to execute all documents and undertake all actions as may be required to implement this resolution. (2/3 *Vote Required*).

A motion was made by Councilor Koloski and seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau to accept 2024-41.

Mayor Girard noted back in January the Council reviewed what the goals were, and stated Not wanting planning grants, but wants implementation grants, and asked why are we applying and not implementing.

Manager Manale noted there are many implementing grants- like the congressional direct spending creating an entrepreneur center.

Mayor Girard stated he was disappointed the manager allowed the Planning and Development Director to apply for this grant.

Councilor Hemingway stated planning grants are a feel-good thing, just kicking down the road.

Councilor Koloski stated having no issue receiving funding from USDA and believes this is a stepping stone.

Councilor Limoges asked if Council rejects this grant, would this jeopardize future grants.

Councilor Zutter asked if this can be brought back.

A motion was made by Councilor O’Heerne and seconded by Councilor Zutter to table Resolution 2024-41 to the next Council meeting.

Roll call:

Koloski – no

Limoges - yes
Matteau – no
Zutter– yes
Hemingway – yes
O’Hearne – yes
Girard – no
Motion carried 4-3

Ordinance 625, 2024 Non-Union Employee Classification Plan Attachment B- Business Development Coordinator/Deputy Director of Planning and Development

Mayor Girard shared concern for the job descriptions not being in the packet, and suggested bringing these positions back with the descriptions. Councilor Koloski agrees.

By Consensus City Council agrees to bring back all positions to another meeting.

Ordinance 629 2024 Non-Union Employee Merit Scale Plan Attachment C Adjustment

Director Young is proposing pay scale adjustments, recommending adding 5% to the minimum for each grade, and increase the maximum with \$10,000.

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Matteau and seconded by Councilor Limoges to accept Ordinance 629 to a second reading.

Mayor Girard opened a public hearing, no one spoke. Mayor Girard closed the public hearing.

Councilor Zutter stated moving in this direction is a positive thing.
Councilor Koloski asked if this effects hourly pay and recused himself from this vote.

Roll call:
Limoges - yes
Matteau – yes
Zutter– yes
Hemingway – yes
O’Hearne – no
Girard – yes
Motion carried 5-1

FY2025 – Public Hearing and Vote

Resolution 2025-1 Tax Anticipation Note

Director Bates explained the tax anticipation note was a line of credit in case the City is short on cash flow, and would not apply for one unless there was a need for it, and there is no fee.

A motion was made by Councilor Koloski and seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau to accept Resolution 2025-1

Roll call:

Koloski – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter– yes

Hemingway – yes

O’Hearne – no

Girard – yes

Motion carried 6-1

Resolution 2025-5 To Adopt the 2025 Downtown Tax Increment Finance District Budget for the City of Claremont – Public Hearing

A motion was made by Councilor Limoges and seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau to accept resolution 2025-5.

Mayor Girard opened a public hearing, no one spoke. Mayor Girard closed the public hearing.

Roll call:

Koloski – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter– yes

Hemingway – yes

O’Hearne – no

Girard – yes

Motion carried 6-1

COMMITTEE REPORTS

Assistant Mayor Matteau noted the Planning Board met on Monday and approved a site plan amendment for Glassworks.

Councilor Hemingway reported for Policy Committee and noted last week they had a closed session with the City Attorney to discuss code of conduct, and decided the wood burners need to first go through Health and Fire.

Councilor Limoges noted the Wall Committee put in an application on Memorial Day and, in the coming weeks they will need to form an ad hoc committee, and would like an account set up for donations like the Purple Heart Project.

FUTURE AGENDA ITEMS AND DIRECTIVES

Assistant Mayor Matteau would like to see the sidewalk issues addressed.

Councilor O'Hearne brought up Pleasant St. Tree pruning, outlets that were damaged in the winter still needing to be fixed, and the mowing across the bridge is growing back.

Manager Manale stated Nancy Merrill had contracted out maintenance of Pleasant St., For Electrical; an electrician is coming through to replace the outlets but unsure of their timeline, as for the grassy area; the goats on the synergy site will be moved.

Assistant Mayor Matteau noted there is a flag corner stuck downtown, and would like it fixed, and stated the door outside the ramp shouldn't be locked before a meeting.

Councilor Koloski questioned gym use at the CSBCC, as a non-profit hosted an event, while others didn't have full use of the gymnasium and wants to limit this happening.

Councilor Koloski noted he had six people complain about the employee spot at the community center being closer to the door. Shared concern for lamp post lights being out downtown, Manager Manale noted the City has scheduled and purchased lights but is waiting for electricians to install.

Councilor Koloski noted the traffic signs on the end of Mulberry St. blocks views, and has had numerous complaints.

Councilor Koloski noted issues of naming city owned property and stated there is an ordinance, and gave an example of the detective's division, and benches in parks. Councilor Koloski wants to make sure these go through the right process.

Councilor Koloski stated not being happy with the special assessment letter.

Councilor Koloski wants part-time employees to also be recognized in the newsletter in the future, along with board members.

Councilor O’Hearne noted the flag at the top of Arrowhead is frayed and should be lit at night.

Councilor O’Hearne also noted the police department flag out back is not illuminated at night.

Councilor Koloski mentioned memorial statue also not being lit at night.

CONSULTATION WITH LEGAL COUNSEL

None.

ADJOURNMENT

At 9:38 p.m., a motion was made by Assistant Mayor Matteau and seconded by Councilor Limoges to adjourn.

Voice vote:

Koloski – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

O’Hearne – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 7-0

Respectfully Submitted,

Julia A. Bizzarro
Clerk to the Council